

Chapter 154-9

Liang Shi handed over the glass still steaming with water vapor. "Why are you wearing my shirt?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't take it. Instead, she held onto Liang Shi's hand and leaned in to drink a few sips. "Can't I?"

After drinking the honey water, even her throat seemed to be soaked with sweetness.

Liang Shi was helpless. "You can."

Xu Qingzhu finished the entire glass before she felt a bit better. Then Liang Shi poured herself a glass of warm water using another cup.

The water was very plain.

While she was drinking, Xu Qingzhu's head kept rubbing back and forth against her back.

Like a cat.

Liang Shi quickly finished drinking and asked her: "What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Xu Qingzhu said, "Do you have anything going on today?"

Liang Shi: "Technically, yes."

Xu Qingzhu asked: "In the afternoon?"

Liang Shi nodded: "I need to be at the set around three."

"Alright." Xu Qingzhu hugged her. "Then can I visit the set?"

"You can... it's just that if you're there, I might not be able to act well?" Liang Shi's tone was somewhat uncertain.

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Why?"

"The actress I have scenes with." Liang Shi said, "She's not as good-looking as you."

It clearly sounded like a line to coax someone, yet Liang Shi said it with utmost sincerity.

Xu Qingzhu was amused by her.

After laughing enough, Xu Qingzhu said softly: "Teacher Liang, lower your head."

Liang Shi was startled. "Why..."

While speaking, she lowered her head as told, but before she could finish her words, they were all swallowed up.

The word "why" got stuck in her throat.

It didn't need to be said at all.

Xu Qingzhu bit her lips. After drinking the honey water, her lips were also tinged with sweetness.

Xu Qingzhu asked her indistinctly: "Is it sweet?"

Liang Shi was flustered by her teasing, her ears turning red as she said: "It's sweet."

Her voice was very soft.

Downstairs, the endless flow of traffic continued. The water under Yujiang Bridge hadn't stopped flowing just because it was winter.

A thin layer of ice had formed on the river surface, but with the sunlight refracting off the ice, you could still see the water flowing beneath.

Xu Qingzhu's foot rested on the top of Liang Shi's foot, drawing closer when kissing her.

Neither needed to speak; they both understood each other's meaning.

The curtains in the room hadn't been drawn open yet, with only a sliver of sunlight penetrating through the gaps.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu made their way from the living room to the bedroom.

When Liang Shi leaned down over her, she asked Xu Qingzhu: "Did you have nightmares last night?"

Xu Qingzhu's gaze paused for a moment, then she smiled: "Maybe because I slept in your arms, I had sweet dreams last night."

Liang Shi chuckled softly: "I have that effect?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded with great sincerity: "Yes."

"As long as you're by my side." Xu Qingzhu said, "They're all sweet dreams."

The last two words changed their tone within Liang Shi's kiss.

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It was an exhilarating feast.

Again and again, like the cicadas that never stopped chirping at the end of summer, as if knowing their time was near, they kept making sounds, wanting the world to remember their existence.

Xu Qingzhu was teased until she cried.

Even when not in an Omega's heat period, being intimate with one's marked partner would still bring tears.

So all her tears were kissed away by Liang Shi, swallowed, and then she was engulfed in great waves.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers fell on her shoulder blades, but afraid of hurting her, she only used her fingernails, not leaving any scratch marks on her beautiful back.

She had wanted to be naughty and leave strawberry marks on her neck, but considering she still had to film, she didn't go too far.

But after getting Liang Shi's permission, she left one strawberry mark after another over her heart.

Liang Shi indulged her with helpless affection.

Indulging her way of seeking security, enjoying her closeness and dependence.

She cried out: "Wife, hold me."

So after it ended, Liang Shi held her tight and carried her to take a bath.

Gentle water flowed past their bodies. Xu Qingzhu went completely limp against Liang Shi.

She pinched her ear in the water, then told her accompanied by the sound of water: "I love you so much, wife."

But Liang Shi didn't dare to say those words back.

Eventually, Xu Qingzhu noticed something was off and asked her softly: "Do you not love me anymore?"

So after bathing and returning to bed, Xu Qingzhu teased her once again.

Liang Shi's sweat fell on Xu Qingzhu's shoulder as she whispered in her ear: "Baby, I love you so much too."

The moment she finished saying those words, Liang Shi suddenly thought of a play she had watched many years ago.

The lyrics went like this: "Love knows not whence it came, yet once begun, it grows ever deeper."¹

The singing was melodious and lingering.

Most people only knew this line, not knowing that it was followed by: "The living may die for it, and the dead may live again. If the living cannot die for love, or the dead cannot be reborn for it, then it is not love at its truest."²

Back then, when Liang Shi saw "not love at its truest," she had only sighed—how could there be so much "truest love" in the world?

Now that she understood the taste of love, she could only sigh as well.

What a "not love at its truest."

When love reached its truest... then what?

For many, there was no "then what" at all.

Footnotes:

¹ "Love knows not whence it came, yet once begun, it grows ever deeper" (情不知所起，一往而深): This famous line is from "The Peony Pavilion" (牡丹亭), a renowned Chinese opera written by Tang Xianzu during the Ming Dynasty (1598). It describes how love arises inexplicably and becomes increasingly profound.

² "The living may die for it, and the dead may live again. If the living cannot die for love, or the dead cannot be reborn for it, then it is not love at its truest" (生者可以死，死可以生。生而不可與死，死而不可復生者，皆非情之至也): This is the continuation of the previous line from "The Peony Pavilion," expressing the ultimate devotion of true love—that one would die for it, and that such love has the power to transcend death itself. The opera tells the story of a woman who dies of lovesickness and is later resurrected through the power of love.